

Closing a \$20 million gap: where the savings actually are

District 65 needs to cut about 10% of its budget. We looked at class sizes, the options on the table, our staffing against the State's funding model, building costs and the closure scenarios.

WHAT SHOULD GUIDE THE PLAN

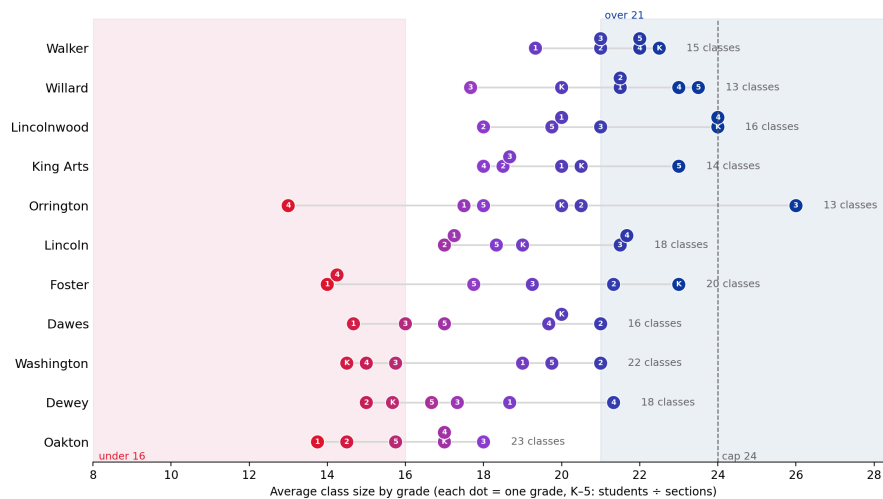
- 1 Decide by outcomes, not dollars.** Orient decisions and accountability toward what students learn, and judge every cut by its effect on the classroom.
- 2 Build a learning organization.** Use data to improve, and be willing to say when something didn't work and change course.
- 3 Engaged families are an asset.** Community groups like ours are part of a healthy district. When parents check out, the system has already failed.

RISK ASSESSMENT: A BUILDING-FIRST PLAN

- HIGH** **Enrollment numbers are off**
May projection: **604** kindergartners; Oct 1: **530** (–12%). About **210** students attend by permissive transfer.
- HIGH** **Receiving schools overfill**
7 of 19 scenarios push a school past capacity.
- HIGH** **Low-enrollment programs**
Closing TWI, ACC or STEP buildings means **moving whole programs**.
- HIGH** **One-time costs and special ed**
Costs **come before savings**; IEP services must continue **uninterrupted**.
- HIGH** **A two-tier system**
Families who can afford it **opt for private school**, leaving D65 with fewer resources and less engaged support.
- MEDIUM** **Transportation costs**
\$150–270K a year per closure, 20–35% of building savings.
- MEDIUM** **Equity**
Closures land on **specific neighborhoods** and TWI access.
- MEDIUM** **Attention is finite**
Closure planning takes time that **staffing decisions** need.

CLASS SIZE AND THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

A child's class size depends on their school and grade



Grade averages run from 13 to 26 students per class. Of the 66 K–5 school-grades (188 sections), **12 average under 16** and **16 average over 21**.

Same grade, different school: a 3rd grader at Dawes or Washington is in a class of about 16; at Orrington, 26 (52 students in 2 sections, over the 24 cap).

Fuller buildings don't have bigger classes ($r = -0.14$). The spread comes from **how grades divide into classes** and from TWI and ACC strands.

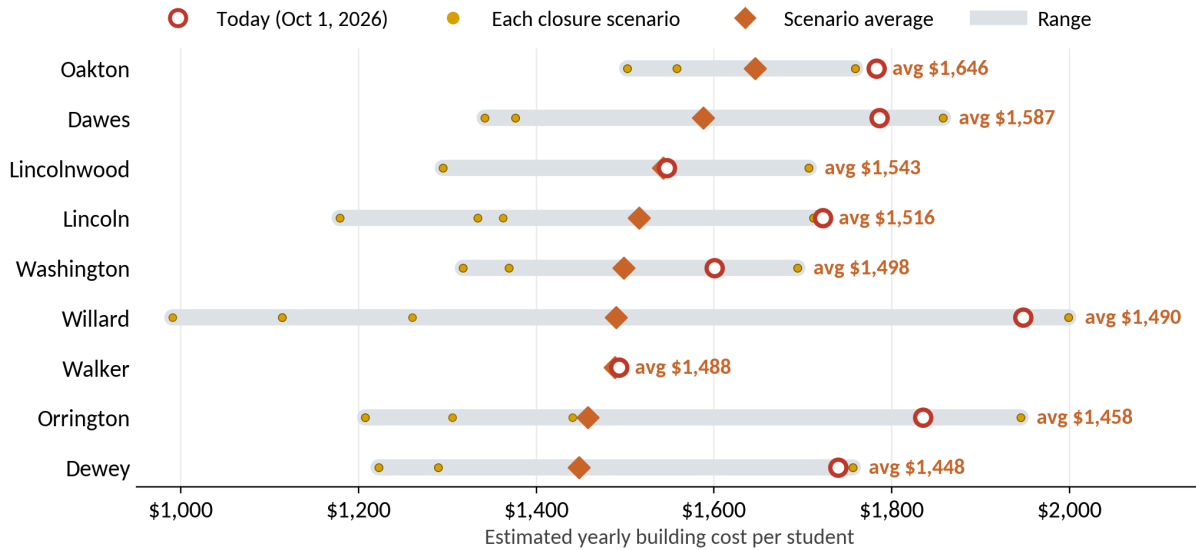
Class size = students in the grade ÷ sections. Sections: District 65's FY27 K–5 section list, a spreadsheet received by email from the district on October 1, 2026. Students: data.district65.net, pulled October 1, 2026.

01 BUILDING COSTS

Which buildings cost the most to run?

Every building carries a principal, an office and custodians whatever its size, so **emptier buildings cost more per student**. At the average closure-scenario enrollment, **Oakton, Dawes and Lincolnwood** cost the most per student; **Dewey and Orrington** the least.

BUILDING COST PER STUDENT: TODAY, EACH CLOSURE SCENARIO, AND THE AVERAGE



BUILDING	STUDENTS OCT 1	UTILIZATION NOW → AVG*	PRINCIPAL + OFFICE	CUSTODIANS	UTILITIES	TOTAL A YEAR	PER STUDENT NOW	PER STUDENT SCENARIO AVG*
Oakton	366	78% → 85%	\$241K	\$345K	\$66K	\$652K	\$1,783	\$1,646
Dawes	284	66% → 74%	\$241K	\$209K	\$58K	\$507K	\$1,786	\$1,587
Lincolnwood	331	77% → 77%	\$241K	\$221K	\$50K	\$512K	\$1,546	\$1,543
Lincoln	340	59% → 67%	\$241K	\$266K	\$79K	\$585K	\$1,722	\$1,516
Washington	380	72% → 77%	\$241K	\$278K	\$90K	\$608K	\$1,600	\$1,498
Willard	272	51% → 67%	\$241K	\$227K	\$62K	\$530K	\$1,948	\$1,490
Walker	318	74% → 74%	\$241K	\$186K	\$48K	\$475K	\$1,493	\$1,488
Orrington	248	57% → 72%	\$241K	\$170K	\$45K	\$455K	\$1,835	\$1,458
Dewey	314	58% → 70%	\$241K	\$236K	\$70K	\$546K	\$1,739	\$1,448
King Arts	445	68%	\$241K	\$362K	\$101K	\$703K	\$1,580	—
Haven (MS)	601	64%	\$241K	\$514K	\$96K	\$850K	\$1,415	—
Chute (MS)	588	74%	\$241K	\$408K	\$102K	\$752K	\$1,278	—
Nichols (MS)	571	81%	\$241K	\$354K	\$83K	\$678K	\$1,187	—

WHAT STANDS OUT

Adding students lowers cost per student only at receiving buildings; the district saves just the closed building's costs. **Utilities are a small share:** \$1.33M district-wide.

DATA WE STILL NEED

Maintenance and capital needs by building (10-year Health/Life Safety survey, facility assessment), likely larger than utilities; **actual building staff by school**; **site-level spending per student** (ISBE report card); **full-year 2026 utilities**.

*Scenario average = today's cost ÷ the building's average 2027–28 enrollment across the closure scenarios on page 3 where it stays open and at or under capacity (90% of displaced students stay). Foster has no utility account. **Sources:** enrollment from data.district65.net, pulled Oct 1, 2026. Utilities and energy use (2025) are from the Sept 23, 2026 pull: the Oct 1 dashboard showed incomplete 2025 utility data for some buildings (for example, Chute and King Arts). Square feet derived from energy use ÷ EUI; capacity = smaller of the district's Cap Total and Cordogan Clark (2022); principal pay, FY26 PA 96-0434 salary report (\$180,753 average); 64 custodians from the district's employee-category table, allocated by square feet. **Assumed:** custodian pay \$65K and office staff \$60K per building. Built with help from Claude (AI); please verify.

02 CLOSURE SCENARIOS What closures would do to the receiving schools

Each closed school's projected 2027–28 students go to its receiving schools, with 90% staying in D65. Pairs close one south school (**Dewey, Washington, Oakton or Dawes**) and one north school (**Willard, Lincolnwood or Orrington**). "Kept together" sends a school to one building; "split" divides it by open seats.

	Dawes	Dewey	Foster	Lincoln	Lincolnwood	Oakton	Orrington	Walker	Washington	Willard
No closures	63%	58%	58%	59%	69%	79%	54%	74%	68%	50%
1. Close Dewey split → 3 schools	63%	closed	75%	76%	69%	79%	73%	74%	68%	50%
2. Close Orrington kept together → 1 school	63%	58%	58%	59%	69%	79%	closed	74%	68%	89%
3a. Close Lincolnwood kept together → 1 school	63%	58%	58%	59%	closed	79%	117%!	74%	68%	50%
3b. Close Lincolnwood split → 2 schools	63%	58%	58%	59%	closed	79%	81%	74%	68%	79%
3c. Close Lincolnwood kept together → 1 school	63%	58%	58%	59%	closed	79%	54%	74%	68%	100%
4. Close Oakton split → 3 schools	85%	83%	58%	59%	69%	closed	54%	74%	87%	50%
5. Close Dawes split → 3 schools	closed	79%	58%	59%	69%	90%	54%	74%	84%	50%
Dewey + Willard Dewey split 3 ways - Willard split 2 ways	63%	closed	75%	76%	92%	79%	106%!	74%	68%	closed
Dewey + Lincolnwood Dewey split 3 ways - Lincolnwood kept together	63%	closed	75%	76%	closed	79%	136%!	74%	68%	50%
Dewey + Orrington Dewey split 3 ways - Orrington kept together	63%	closed	74%	75%	69%	79%	closed	74%	68%	108%!
Washington + Willard Washington split 3 ways - Willard split 2 ways	88%	58%	58%	86%	92%	93%	87%	74%	closed	closed
Washington + Lincolnwood Washington split 3 ways - Lincolnwood kept together	88%	58%	58%	86%	closed	93%	117%!	74%	closed	50%
Washington + Orrington Washington split 3 ways - Orrington kept together	88%	58%	58%	86%	69%	93%	closed	74%	closed	89%
Oakton + Willard Oakton split 3 ways - Willard split 2 ways	85%	83%	58%	59%	92%	closed	87%	74%	87%	closed
Oakton + Lincolnwood Oakton split 3 ways - Lincolnwood kept together	85%	83%	58%	59%	closed	closed	117%!	74%	87%	50%
Oakton + Orrington Oakton split 3 ways - Orrington kept together	85%	83%	58%	59%	69%	closed	closed	74%	87%	89%
Dawes + Willard Dawes split 3 ways - Willard split 2 ways	closed	79%	58%	59%	92%	90%	87%	74%	84%	closed
Dawes + Lincolnwood Dawes split 3 ways - Lincolnwood kept together	closed	79%	58%	59%	closed	90%	117%!	74%	84%	50%
Dawes + Orrington Dawes split 3 ways - Orrington kept together	closed	79%	58%	59%	69%	90%	closed	74%	84%	89%

Under 70% (lighter = emptier) 70–89% 90% and up
! = over capacity. Capacity = smaller of district Cap Total and Cordogan Clark. Receiving schools and splits as described in closure_scenarios.md.

ONE CLOSURE

Dewey, split three ways, leaves every receiver at 73–76%, but its TWI strand needs a new home. **Orrington** kept together fills Willard to 89% and all 24 of its classrooms.

Lincolnwood kept together doesn't fit: Orrington would reach 117%, with 23 classes for 19 classrooms. Sent whole to Willard instead, it lands right at the limit (100%, 25 classes for 24 classrooms). Splitting it between Orrington and Willard fits (81% and 79%), but every grade is divided between two schools. STEP moves either way.

Oakton, the fullest building today, splits three ways into Dawes, Washington and Dewey at 83–87%. Oakton's TWI strand and ACC program both need new hosts.

Dawes splits three ways into Oakton, Washington and Dewey at 79–90%, with classrooms to spare at each. It displaces the fewest students of any south closure. Its TWI strand would move to Dewey or Oakton.

TWO CLOSURES

Six pairs keep every receiver under capacity: Washington, Oakton or Dawes, paired with Willard or Orrington. Even these reach 89–93% somewhere, and each moves at least one TWI strand.

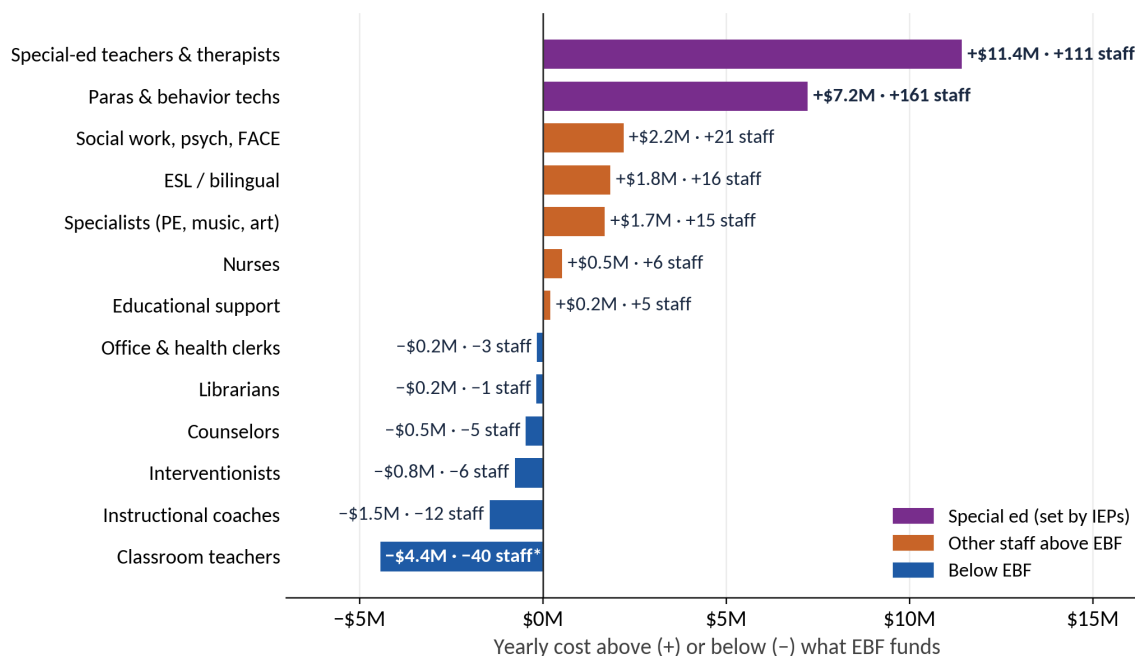
Every pair with Dewey or Lincolnwood overfills Orrington or Willard, up to 136%. TWI at Dewey, Washington, Oakton and Dawes, ACC at Oakton and STEP at Lincolnwood make relocation costly.

Each pair could lose **25–101 students** from the district.

Projection: Oct 1, 2026 enrollment; grades roll forward one year; incoming K = this year's K. Capacity = smaller of the district's Cap Total and Cordogan Clark. Washington's receivers follow the district's SDRP 3D table; Willard's, Oakton's and Dawes's are assumed from geography. Full tables at 85%, 90% and 95% retention are in projections/v2_2026-10-01/closure_scenarios.md. Estimates built with help from Claude (AI); please verify.

03 STATE FUNDING MODEL (EBF) How K-5 staffing compares with Evidence-Based Funding

Illinois's Evidence-Based Funding formula sets out how many staff the State pays for. On paper, D65 has about 267 more K-5 staff than EBF funds, worth \$17.5M a year. Special education explains all of that difference.



+\$18.7M

Special-ed teachers, therapists and paras above EBF's ratio of 1 teacher and 1 aide per 141 students. Staffing follows IEPs and federal law, so this can't simply be cut to match.

+\$6.5M

Other groups above EBF: social workers and psychologists (\$2.2M), ESL teachers (\$1.8M), specialists (\$1.7M), nurses (\$0.5M).

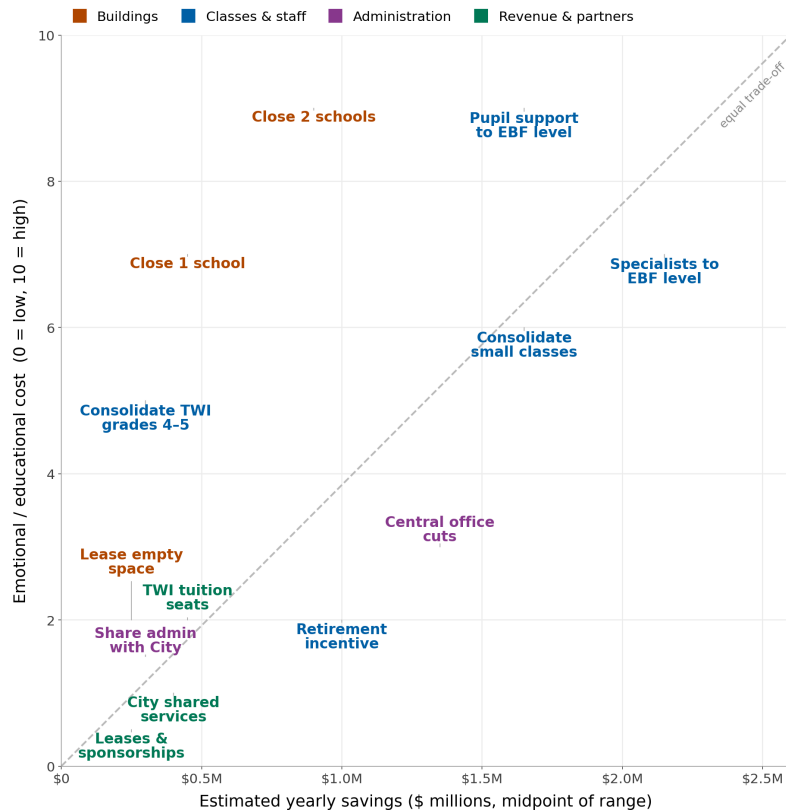
-\$7.6M

Where we're below EBF: classroom teachers, instructional coaches (6 vs. 17), interventionists and counselors.

K-5 STAFFING	1 SCHOOL	9 SCHOOLS	10 SCHOOLS	11 (TODAY)
Staff EBF funds	416	451	466	478
Staff we have (est.)	745	745	745	745
Yearly cost above EBF	\$24.7M	\$20.7M	\$19.0M	\$17.5M
Special ed and paras	\$18.7M	\$18.7M	\$18.7M	\$18.7M
Everything else	\$6.0M	\$2.0M	\$0.3M	-\$1.1M

EBF is a funding model, not a staffing rule. *The classroom-teacher figure is an upper bound: split evenly over 11 buildings, every grade rounds up to 3 classes. Staff other than classroom teachers are estimated for K-5 at 64% of the district count. Some non-teaching pay is assumed. Ratios from 105 ILCS 5/18-8.15. K-5 enrollment (3,484) and English learners from data.district65.net, pulled Oct 1, 2026.

04 THE OPTIONS What each option saves, and what it costs students



Plotting savings against harm puts the choices side by side. Options under the dashed line save more for less disruption to students and families.

WHERE THE MONEY IS

Consolidating small classes, bringing specialist and support staffing closer to EBF levels, and central-office cuts each save \$1–2.6M a year. One closure saves \$0.2–0.7M.

SMALL BUT LOW-HARM

Leasing empty space, TWI tuition seats, shared City services and sponsorships each bring in \$0.1–0.6M, with little effect on classrooms.

ABOUT THE SCORES

The cost-to-students scores are a first draft for discussion. The savings ranges are rough; items marked "estimate" below are illustrative.

OPTION	YEARLY SAVINGS	HOW WE ESTIMATED IT
Close 1 school	\$0.2–0.7M	Building-use analysis: building savings minus added busing (net per closure)
Close 2 schools	\$0.4–1.4M	Two times the per-closure net; relocation and renovation costs not included
Lease or share empty space	\$0.1–0.4M	Estimate: preschool or community partner leases in underused wings
Consolidate small classes	\$1.1–2.2M	10–20 fewer sections × ~\$111K average teacher pay (EBF analysis)
Consolidate TWI strands in grades 4–5	\$0.2–0.4M	2–4 fewer upper-grade TWI sections × ~\$111K
Specialist teachers to EBF level	\$1.7–2.6M	15–22 FTE above EBF × ~\$115K (EBF Table 3)
Pupil support to EBF level	\$1.1–2.2M	Half to all of the 21 social work/psych/FACE FTE above EBF × ~\$103K
Voluntary retirement incentive	\$0.5–1.5M	Estimate: 25–40 retirements replaced at lower step pay net of incentive
Central office admin cuts	\$0.9–1.8M	Estimate: 5–10 central office positions × ~\$180K total comp
Share admin services with City	\$0.1–0.5M	Estimate: shared office space and personnel (creative ideas menu)
TWI tuition seats	\$0.3–0.6M	Estimate: 20–40 tuition students × ~\$15K
City shared services	\$0.2–0.6M	Estimate: crossing guards, maintenance, purchasing (creative ideas menu)
Cell tower, solar and sponsorship revenue	\$0.1–0.4M	Estimate: cell tower, solar panel and facility sponsorship revenue (creative ideas menu)

What families should hear: priorities, what they get, and how we'll know

Families will judge any plan by what happens in their child's classroom. The plan should say plainly what it protects, what changes, and how the district will show it's working.

OUR PRIORITIES

What comes first

- **Class sizes in a set range** for every grade at every school
- **Children stay with their classmates and teachers** wherever possible
- **Programs families chose stay whole:** TWI, ACC, STEP
- **Every IEP is fully served**, through any change
- **Savings reinvested** where EBF says we're short: coaching and intervention

WHAT FAMILIES GET

What changes for them

- **Predictable class sizes**, published for each school and grade
- **A clear plan for any building move:** the timeline, the receiving school, busing, and how classmates stay together
- **More reading and math intervention** as savings are reinvested
- **A clear budget:** what was cut, what it saved, where it went

EDUCATIONAL OUTCOMES

How we'll know it's working

- **Class size by school and grade**, every fall
- **Reading and math growth** by school and student group
- **Attendance and chronic absence**
- **Special-ed service minutes delivered** vs. IEPs
- **Families staying in D65:** transfers in, out and to private schools

VALUES TO EMPHASIZE

Families and staff will need both words and action: tell them what to expect, then follow through.

Empathy

Listen to families and staff before deciding. Acknowledge what a change means for a school community, and show it in what the plan does, not only in what it says.

Accountability

Tie every decision to what students learn. Do what the plan promises, report the results, and say so when something isn't working and change course.

Transparency

Tell families and staff what to expect and when: what's being considered, the timeline, what changes for each child and each job, and what each choice saves.

KEY MESSAGES

"We're protecting what happens in the classroom first: class sizes, programs, and every child's services."

"We'll make the biggest savings where they do the least harm, and we'll show our work."

The class-size range is for the district and community to set.



RECAP

The whole brief on one page

1–3.5%

of the \$20M target from one closure, after busing (\$0.2–0.7M a year)

\$18.7M

special-ed staffing above EBF's ratio: the whole gap, set by IEPs

7 of 19

closure scenarios push a receiving school over capacity

23 of 66

K–5 grades average under 18 students per class (Oct 1, 2026)

TAKEAWAYS

- Class size depends on school and grade:** grade averages run from 13 to 26 students and don't track how full a building is ($r = -0.14$). p. 1
- Emptier buildings cost more per student:** \$1,490–\$1,950 today. Receivers get cheaper per student, but the district saves only the closed building's costs. p. 2
- Where students go decides if a closure fits.** Every scenario that overfills sends students into Orrington or Willard; TWI, STEP and ACC moves are costly. Closing Dawes fits, split among Oakton, Washington and Dewey. p. 3
- Special ed explains the whole EBF gap.** Without it we're \$1.1M below the model, and short on coaches and interventionists. p. 4
- Staffing and class structure save more:** \$1–2.6M each, against \$0.2–0.7M per closure. p. 5
- Tell families what's protected, what they get, and how the district will know it's working.** p. 6

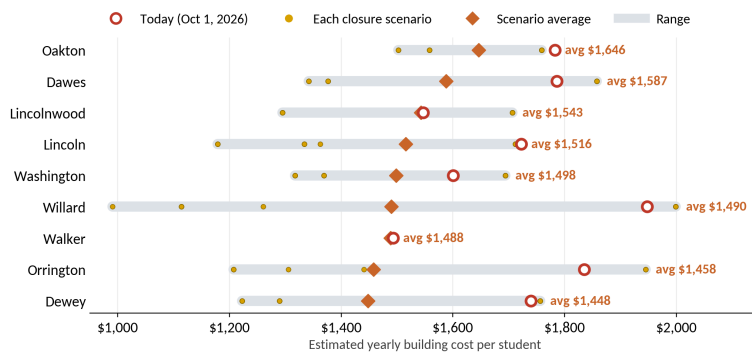
WHAT WE'RE ASKING

What to convey in the plan

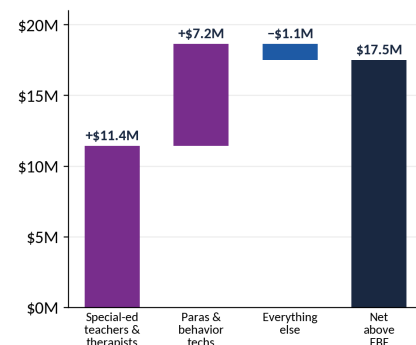
- Itemized savings from the Kingsley and Bessie Rhodes closures, net of opening Foster.
- The full cost of closing and relocating a school, including TWI, STEP and ACC moves.
- Which positions would be cut, by category, and what each saves.
- Class counts and class sizes by grade, before and after, not just utilization.
- How the plan improves outcomes for students, not only this year's budget.

Decide by outcomes, learn from the data, and treat engaged families as an asset. We need to work with the buildings and the district we have.

BUILDING COST PER STUDENT



STAFFING ABOVE EBF



UTILIZATION IN EVERY CLOSURE SCENARIO, 2027–28

	Dawes	Dewey	Foster	Lincoln	Lincolnwood	Oakton	Orrington	Walker	Washington	Willard
No closures	83%	58%	58%	59%	69%	79%	54%	74%	68%	50%
1. Close Dawes (split 100% to Willard)	closed	58%	75%	76%	69%	79%	73%	74%	68%	50%
2. Close Orrington (split 100% to Willard)	62%	58%	58%	59%	69%	79%	closed	74%	68%	69%
3a. Close Lincolnwood (split 100% to Willard)	62%	58%	58%	59%	closed	79%	117%	74%	68%	50%
3b. Close Lincolnwood (split 50% to Willard)	62%	58%	58%	59%	closed	79%	81%	74%	68%	79%
3c. Close Lincolnwood (split 50% to Dewey)	62%	58%	58%	59%	closed	79%	54%	74%	68%	100%
4. Close Oakton (split 100% to Willard)	83%	83%	58%	59%	69%	closed	54%	74%	67%	50%
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Dewey + Lincolnwood (Dewey split 2 ways; Lincolnwood split 100% to Willard)	62%	closed	75%	76%	closed	79%	100%	74%	68%	50%
Dewey + Orrington (Dewey split 2 ways; Orrington split 100% to Willard)	62%	closed	74%	75%	69%	79%	closed	74%	68%	100%
Washington + Willard (Washington split 2 ways; Willard split 2 ways)	88%	58%	58%	84%	92%	92%	67%	74%	closed	50%
Washington + Lincolnwood (Washington split 2 ways; Lincolnwood split 100% to Willard)	88%	58%	58%	84%	closed	92%	117%	74%	closed	50%
Washington + Orrington (Washington split 2 ways; Orrington split 100% to Willard)	88%	58%	58%	84%	69%	92%	closed	74%	closed	69%
Oakton + Willard (Oakton split 2 ways; Willard split 2 ways)	83%	83%	58%	59%	100%	closed	54%	74%	67%	50%
Oakton + Lincolnwood (Oakton split 2 ways; Lincolnwood split 100% to Willard)	83%	83%	58%	59%	closed	closed	117%	74%	67%	50%
Oakton + Orrington (Oakton split 2 ways; Orrington split 100% to Willard)	83%	83%	58%	59%	69%	closed	closed	74%	67%	69%
Dawes + Willard (Dawes split 100% to Willard; Willard split 2 ways)	closed	79%	58%	59%	92%	90%	67%	74%	64%	closed
Dawes + Lincolnwood (Dawes split 100% to Lincolnwood; Lincolnwood split 100% to Willard)	closed	79%	58%	59%	closed	90%	117%	74%	64%	50%
Dawes + Orrington (Dawes split 100% to Orrington; Orrington split 100% to Willard)	closed	79%	58%	59%	69%	90%	closed	74%	64%	69%

100% = over capacity. Capacity = number of district Cap Test and Condingham. Based on school and splits as described in closure scenarios and